

memes have moved in order to survive and thrive at a rapid pace. Internet memes are a niche kind of meme, which is why many die so easily and none last too long. Another contributing factor is that internet memes generally provide entertainment value more than anything else, and things get old quickly.

So what is a meme really? An idea... A concept... A thought... All of that and yet more than that.



Since memes are replicators, it is very tempting to draw an analogy (as many do) with an existing and well-known replicator – DNA, or more aptly genes. In fact, the word ‘gene’ is the model Dawkins had in mind when he coined the word meme from ‘mimeme’, which is Ancient Greek and means “imitated thing”. The various traits of any specimen of any life form are representative of its genes, and are transmitted forward in time across individuals via the complexly simple act of replication. So too various aspects of human culture and social life are propagated in memes. However, this analogy is better not carried too far. Genes are a specific units of life’s chemistry. Despite much debate and discussion, it is still unclear what a meme exactly is. Actually, it would be strangely more appropriate to say, it is unclear how much a meme is. A meme is a pseudo-unit. Whether a word, a sentence, or an entire book, there are no lines when it comes to memes. A single meme is anything that has the meaning of a single theme. When they get any larger, they are to be called a memplex – many memes mutually supporting each other. For example, to someone only vaguely familiar with ‘Star Wars’, ‘Star Wars’ itself is a meme. To them it’s ‘that sci-fi movie with the laser swords and stuff’; but to anyone more knowledgeable, ‘Star Wars’ is an intricate memplex. Considering this new person to be only slightly more knowledgeable for simplicity, in the slightly expanded Star Wars memplex, the Jedi, the Sith, and the Force are mutually supportive

memes. They do not have to support each other literally, of course. The antagonist requires the protagonist and vice versa, if only to fight against. This again, may be thought of as an example of the Duality meme, which is a part of the ‘nature of the world’ memplex, which in turn is a part of the curiosity memplex.. And down the rabbit hole we go.

Instead of delving deeper into the abyss of defining a meme (which can only be done in terms of memes), let us consider some more of the characteristics of a meme so that we can notice and observe them in the real world:

Imitation and virality

Memes spread via imitation. What is essentially done, when you share a post? Unless you made your own content, you just successfully imitated the creator of that post’s content. You spread someone else’s idea. Even if you



Spread memes that make the world a better place!

are intelligent enough to understand it, you didn’t create it. Even if you added your own caption or modified some detail, you just helped the meme evolve a little, and then you helped it spread when you clicked the ‘Share’ button. Actually, even if you made a meme, it’s going to die out unless enough people repost. Here is the first deviation from the Gene analogy: Genes (life molecules in general) have a design that ensures they replicate themselves. Their replication is an intrinsic characteristic. Memes on the other hand, replicate and evolve thanks to willing participants (assuming all participants have free will and think for themselves). Memes need people, sentient

beings, in whose minds they reside and spread from. Keep in mind, you are always at the end of the branch of the spread of any meme you come across. It is you who decides if the meme is worth storing in your brain and telling other people about, or better forgotten and never mentioned. Memes need your belief to be recreated rather than replicated. When it comes to internet memes, they need your reposts!

Memplexes like entire religions are a good example of well designed memes, even if they didn’t start as conscious designs but merely came about as memes for the inexplicable. Religions contain memes that help people cope better with the realities of the world, and so they spread. A large number of people like to believe there is a life after death, and so the meme survives. Although this meme has been around for a long time, imagine no one had ever thought of it before. When

people suddenly start liking the new meme of ‘life after death’, and we’d say it is going viral. Virality is exponential imitation, and a good meme is conducive to it.

Unnatural selection and evolution

Genes undergo natural selection as a trial by fire in the real world. If they are not helpful (and sometimes they

are helpful by being unhelpful, such as the flamboyant plumage for the peacock) the individuals possessing those genes do not survive, and thus, they exit the gene pool. For memes, it’s more of a reality show than a trial by fire. Memes must proliferate in the socio-intellectual world, not the physical real world. The memes that survive and thrive are the memes that people like. And people like a meme when they relate to it, it helps them understand something, makes the world better for them, or they just generally find it entertaining. Unhelpful memes survive easily too if they are entertaining or compelling enough. In general, we tend to like memes which